



The introduction of han'gul

The new Korean alphabet, today called han'gul, is thought to have been largely the work of King Sejong himself and is based on a careful analysis of the Korean language. It was first revealed in 1443 and then formally introduced by the king in 1446 in a ceremony depicted here in a modern Korean painting.

But han'gul was more than just a project to bring literacy to the lower levels of society. Like much that Sejong did, it was also an attempt to reflect the order of Neo-Confucianism. It divides the sounds of the Korean language into the two components of the universal principle—yin (dark, female, passive) and yang (light, male, active).

Alongside the new alphabet, King Sejong encouraged the advancement of sciences, particularly astronomy and meteorology, which sought to understand the function of the heavens (see left). His attention also extended into the reform of court music, the encouragement of refined painting that depicted the natural world, and the spread of new agricultural techniques to the country's farmers.

A society of unequals

The foundations of the Choson dynasty rested upon more than just the will of a determined, farsighted king. The Neo-Confucianism that dominated the thinking of Sejong and his officials reflected the reality of Choson's unequal society and actually helped to reinforce its rigid class structures.

The great majority of the population were peasants engaged in agriculture, paying taxes to the state and rent to landlords, and often finding themselves at the mercy of the floods and droughts that beset the Korean peninsula's fragile ecology, bringing with them famine and disease. Beneath the farmers on the social scale were various lowborn groups,

including those involved in so-called "dirty occupations" such as butchery and leatherworking. There was also a large hereditary

Chongmyo ritual

At Chongmyo Shrine in Seoul, the Choson kings frequently held elaborate Confucian rites as a way of honoring their royal ancestors.



"I have ... designed **28 letters**, which I wish to have **everyone** practice at their ease."

KING SEJONG, PREFACE TO "CORRECT SOUNDS," 1446

published in 1446: "The sounds of our country's language are different from those of China and are not easily conveyed in Chinese writing. Among the ignorant people there have been a great many who ... have been unable to express their feelings."

Despite the many achievements of the 15th century, problems in the political system of the Choson dynasty began to appear.

INVASION FROM THE EAST

The 16th century saw the rise of a vicious rivalry among the scholar-officials who vied for position in the state bureaucracy and at court. The emphasis that Choson placed on literary scholarship and its favoritism toward a civil rather than military bureaucracy had serious consequences. When **Japan invaded** in the 1590s, the country was unprepared. After two invasions in six years brought devastation for the country and its people, the invaders were finally

repelled with military aid from Ming China. The 16th century saw the rise of a vicious rivalry among the scholar-officials who vied for position in the state bureaucracy and at court. The emphasis that Choson placed on literary scholarship and its favoritism toward a civil rather than military bureaucracy had serious consequences. When **Japan invaded** in the 1590s, the country was unprepared. After two invasions in six years brought devastation for the country and its people, the invaders were finally



Punch'ong ware

Freely decorated ceramics, such as this elegant vase, characterized the earthy aesthetics of the period.

In accordance with his ideology, Sejong sought to encourage appropriate relationships between the different classes and cultivate decorum in personal relations.

In 1432, he ordered the publication of a didactic text on Neo-Confucian ethics called the *Illustrated Guide to the Three Bonds*, which was reprinted later that century with a han'gul text so that a general readership could benefit from its instructions.

The three bonds of the title were those that occur between parents and children, between ruler and official, and between husband and wife. Each example of bond was illustrated with a series of short biographies and woodcuts depicting the

stories of devoted sons and daughters, loyal officials, and faithful wives.

But the less lofty lives of the common people found an expression in the arts of this period, in particular through punch'ong ceramics. These developed from the refined celadon ceramics—crackle-glazed porcelain in a range of jadelike colors—favored by the Koryo court in previous centuries. The freedom of their incised and stamped designs has often been cited as a key feature of the Korean artistic style, and this apparently artless but graceful form of pottery had a deep influence on Japanese ceramics. Korea's impact on the art in Japan saw a dramatic increase after potters were taken from Korea back to Japan by invading armies in the late 16th century.

repelled with military aid from Ming China. The 16th century saw the rise of a vicious rivalry among the scholar-officials who vied for position in the state bureaucracy and at court. The emphasis that Choson placed on literary scholarship and its favoritism toward a civil rather than military bureaucracy had serious consequences. When **Japan invaded** in the 1590s, the country was unprepared. After two invasions in six years brought devastation for the country and its people, the invaders were finally

RECOVERY AND RENOVATION

Choson recovered during the 17th century, but the **fall of China's Ming dynasty** to Manchu "barbarians" in 1644 was a profound shock. The rulers of Choson then saw themselves as the true defenders of civilization and Neo-Confucian orthodoxy. Two kings, Yongjo and Chongjo, ruled for much of the 18th century and the country prospered. A move away from Neo-Confucianism toward solving practical problems and an interest in new ideas from China and Europe followed.



Hunmin Chong'um

The opening pages of *Correct Sounds for the Instruction of the People* contain Sejong's explanation of the new script in both Chinese characters and han'gul. The book was first printed in 1446 at the time of the introduction of the new phonetic script for the Korean language.

KOREAN KING (1397–1450)

KING SEJONG

The fourth king of a relatively young dynasty, Sejong came to the throne of Choson (Korea) in 1418 at the age of 22. He was the grandson of the dynastic founder Yi Songgye and became the first king to be extensively schooled from an early age in Neo-Confucian philosophy and ethics. Today, Sejong the Great is a national icon symbolizing Korea's first "golden age" and is seen by many millions of Koreans every day on the back of the 10,000-won note.

